SPOTLIGHT

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An AI-ready data foundation is not only a technical necessity; it is a strategic asset that drives measurable improvements in operational and financial performance.

Future-Ready Data Foundation: From AI Pilot to Production Value

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Introduction

Miss the next 12 months on data readiness and rivals may be first to lock in AI advantages around speed, accuracy, and customer trust. The urgency to modernize data foundations is intensifying as organizations face mounting pressure to deliver AI-driven outcomes. Despite the widespread enthusiasm for AI, only 37% of AI initiatives progress from proof of concept to production (source: IDC's *Future Enterprise Resiliency and Spending Survey,* July 2025). This stark gap highlights a critical need for robust, scalable, and trusted data architectures that can support the transition from experimentation to operationalized AI. The inability to move beyond pilot projects is often rooted in foundational data challenges, including fragmented data environments, inconsistent governance, and insufficient data quality controls.

In today's enterprise landscape, data is increasingly distributed, diverse, and dynamic. Various technologies manage data, which is stored in a multitude of formats. Data is constantly changing in response to business events and external stimuli, further complicating the landscape. Modern data distribution, diversity, and dynamism challenge traditional data management approaches and impede AI readiness.

AT A GLANCE

KEY STAT

» Organizations investing in enterprise intelligence services report significant gains on average, including 24% faster innovation, a 23% increase in operational efficiency, a 23% improvement in business agility, 21% revenue growth, and 19% cost savings, according to IDC's June 2025 *Enterprise Intelligence Services Survey*.

WHAT'S IMPORTANT

» Investing in AI-ready data is crucial for maximizing return on AI investments. As organizations scale AI initiatives, a strong data foundation becomes essential.

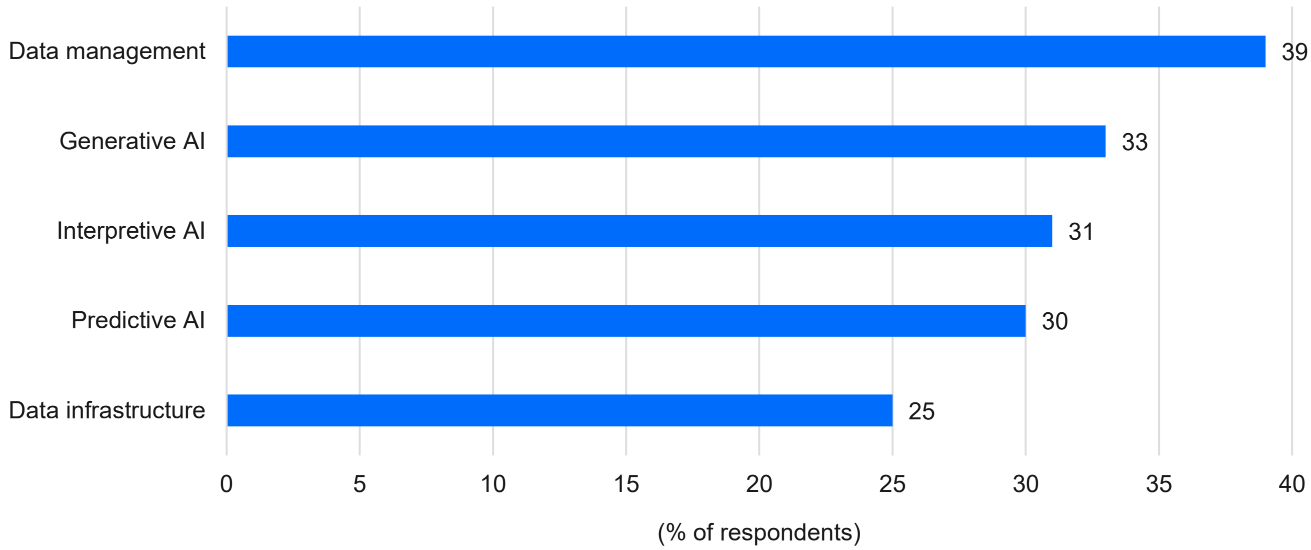
» Data foundation services offer a pathway to measurable improvement in agility, efficiency, and innovation.

When organizations overlook critical elements of the AI road map, such as robust data management and integration, their AI initiatives often stall or fail, as fragmented and complex data environments undermine the reliability, scalability, and impact of AI solutions; this underscores the need for a unified data foundation built on well-defined data products to enable AI success. Establishing a unified, AI-ready data foundation includes integrating data intelligence and governance and real-time access to data products. This approach enables organizations to scale predictive, generative, and agentic AI across workflows, ensuring that data is not only accessible but also trustworthy and actionable. Achieving this level of readiness is no trivial undertaking. Data management has emerged as the top technology investment priority for organizations over the next 18 months (see Figure 1), surpassing even direct investments in AI technologies.

This prioritization reflects a growing recognition that the success of AI initiatives fundamentally depends on the quality and readiness of underlying data assets.

FIGURE 1: ***Technology Investment Priorities***

Q ***Which of the following will be your organization's most important areas of technology investment related to enterprise intelligence in the next 18 months?***



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Source: IDC's Enterprise Intelligence Services Survey, June 2025

By leveraging data management and modernization services to help build a robust data foundation that supports enterprise intelligence, organizations can unlock measurable improvements in business agility, cost savings, and operational efficiency. These improvements are not merely theoretical; they are being realized by companies that have made strategic investments in their data infrastructure, positioning themselves to capitalize on AI's transformative potential.

Benefits

Establishing a robust data foundation to enable enterprise intelligence is a strategic imperative for organizations aiming to scale AI and drive digital transformation, underscored by its direct impact on operational efficiency, innovation, and risk mitigation.

Businesses increasingly recognize that successful AI initiatives depend on the quality and the readiness of their data. An AI-ready data foundation is not only a technical necessity; it is a strategic asset that drives measurable improvements in operational and financial performance. Organizations with mature data foundations achieve a 6% improvement in operational metrics and a 4% increase in financial metrics, supporting effective and scalable AI and analytics deployments (source: IDC's *Office of the CDO Survey,* August 2024).

Investing in AI-ready data is crucial for maximizing returns on AI investments and achieving long-term success. Critical factors for enabling AI to deliver meaningful outcomes include data accessibility, trustworthiness, and alignment with business objectives. As organizations scale AI initiatives, a strong data foundation becomes even more essential, enabling faster innovation cycles and sustainable business outcomes. Treating data as a product, rather than a by-product, accelerates time to value and fosters innovation. This mindset ensures the curation, governance, and management of data with clear ownership, supporting reliable and relevant AI models. In IDC's *Office of the CDO Survey,* organizations adopting data product approaches report 9% faster time to value and an 11% improvement in innovation KPIs.

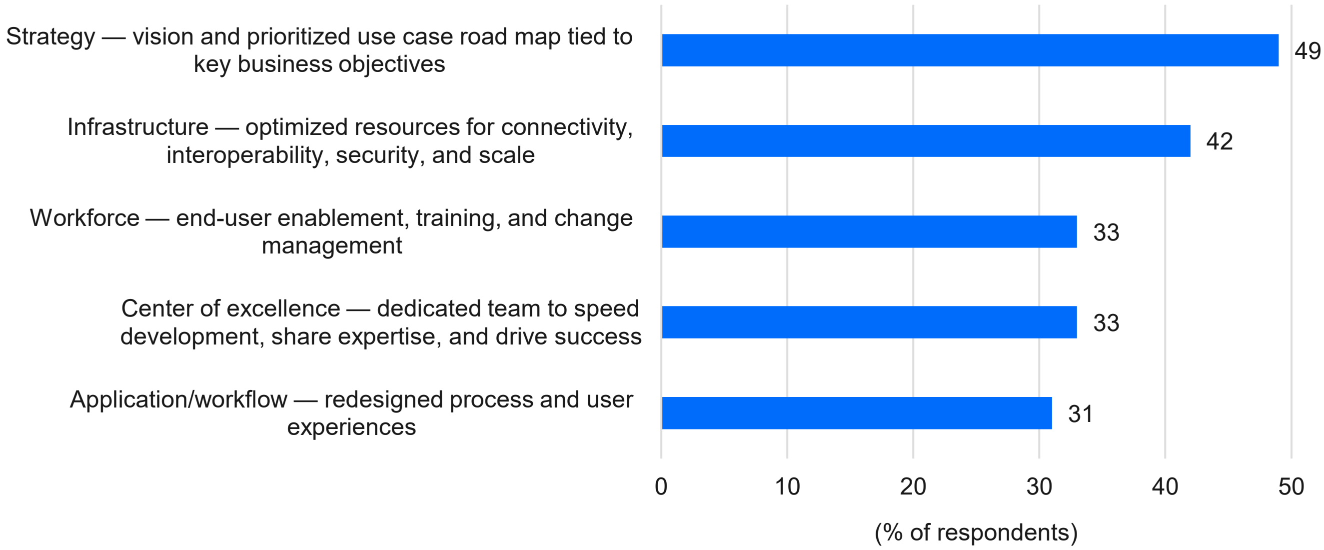
In the same survey, organizations that use data products consistently report significantly higher rates of success across key data practices compared with those that do not. For example, the survey found that 73% of organizations with data products experience ease of data access and utility versus just 13% of those without data products; similarly, 67% find it easy to incorporate data into decision-making, compared with only 2% of those without data products. This strong correlation extends to mature data governance, digital transformation, and the deployment of generative AI, highlighting that the adoption of data products is closely linked to more effective and advanced data management practices.

Establishing a solid data foundation is the beginning of achieving unified data solutions. Unified data is valuable for organizations seeking to streamline data, analytics, and decision-making processes. This unified foundation includes data intelligence (cataloging and lineage), semantics, master data management, real-time event stream processing, and privacy by design. Businesses can accelerate their data cleansing and data literacy journeys by leveraging unification and supporting proper storage, management, and governance practices in the creation of data products tied to business value and outcomes. A data control plane is part of this unified foundation, controlling access, movement, cleansing, and observability of operations to manage data drift and shift. Once this unified foundation is established with data products, organizations have a better opportunity for success with predictive, interpretive, generative, and agentic AI initiatives.

Implementing each of these capabilities must be done iteratively, and value needs to be realized early to secure funding for further initiatives. Unifying data for use with AI may start with a specific data domain or business process, focusing first on laying a foundation within a manageable scope that delivers real value. The benefits of unified data are also contingent upon the organization's commitment to data literacy for both technical and business users. Without training and change management prioritization, users may not fully leverage platform capabilities. Services partners can help with iterative implementation and organizational changes to improve solution adoption. Organizational changes are top of mind for companies working with service providers to encourage broader internal adoption of their enterprise intelligence solutions (see Figure 2). If these elements aren't handled, enterprises risk pilot purgatory.

FIGURE 2: ***Organizational Investment Priorities***

Q ***What are your organization's top priorities to enable broader adoption of solutions related to foundational enterprise intelligence initiatives in the next 12 months?***



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Source: IDC's Enterprise Intelligence Services Survey, June 2025

Trends

Understanding current and emerging trends is vital for organizations seeking to future proof their data strategies and maximize AI's impact across the enterprise. The following trends are reshaping the landscape of data foundation services and enterprise intelligence:

- **Data modernization:** A pronounced shift exists toward unified, open, and modular data architectures, such as data lakehouses, and the adoption of open table formats, such as Apache Iceberg, to enable interoperability, future proofing, and flexibility. The emphasis is on consolidating disparate data sources and repositories, streamlining data integration and transformation processes, and automating data management to reduce complexity and support trustworthy analytics. Investments in data modernization are especially high for AI-committed organizations, with a focus on platforms that support open APIs, cloud-native deployment, and strong ecosystem integration to avoid vendor lock-in. The benefits of modernization include cost optimization, improved collaboration, enhanced decision-making, and the ability to adapt quickly to emerging technologies and business needs.
- **Data for AI:** By 2027, 80% of agentic AI use cases will require real-time, contextual, and ubiquitous data delivery and access, prompting a shift from centralized to federated data models (see *IDC FutureScape: Worldwide Data and Analytics 2026 Predictions,* IDC #US53860225, October 2025). A data control plane will be critical to enable domain-specific data products in federated environments. This evolution is driven by the need for AI agents to access domain-specific data in real time, reducing latency and enabling faster, more relevant decision-making. Organizations are moving away from rigid, centralized data repositories to architectures that allow data to remain

within domain-specific systems, with the application of governance and access controls at the edges, ultimately unifying data.

- **AI for data:** Enterprise intelligence agents are emerging, transforming data management, engineering, and governance across enterprise intelligence architectures. Activities that intelligent agents may be able to perform in the future include orchestrating data placement, processing, and movement; enhancing data quality; and ensuring real-time accessibility to structured and unstructured data, reducing manual intervention and improving efficiency. Once these agents have matured, they will enable organizations to automate complex processes, improve data quality, and accelerate the delivery of insights.
- **Partnering with service providers:** Expertise, modernized delivery, and innovation influence the selection of service providers. Organizations cite the quality of skills and knowledge related to data platforms, data analytics and AI, or data-driven business activities as the most important criteria in selecting a vendor. They also look for services that leverage AI-enabled automation, technical insights and competency, technology, and innovation. The most important component of a successful enterprise intelligence services engagement is the connection between the services vendors deliver to improve measurable business value and ROI. Organizations investing in enterprise intelligence services report significant gains on average, including 24% faster innovation, a 23% increase in operational efficiency, a 23% improvement in business agility, 21% revenue growth, and 19% cost savings, according to IDC's June 2025 *Enterprise Intelligence Services Survey*.

These trends highlight the growing importance of decentralized architectures, continuous governance, and automation in enabling AI-native enterprise intelligence. Organizations that align with these shifts will be in a better position to unlock new business models, drive innovation, and sustain competitive advantage.

Considering Qlik and Artha Solutions' Data Foundation Services

Artha + Qlik can be described as a system: Artha operationalizes governance, quality, and AI readiness as a repeatable operating model, while Qlik Talend delivers an integration backbone (CDC/replication, ELT, and federation) to swiftly move trusted data. Together, they seek to eliminate the obstacles to AI at scale, such as fragmentation, missing lineage/quality, and slow time to production. Qlik's advanced AI (e.g., Qlik Answers, AutoML) is designed to accelerate adoption by putting explainable predictions and natural-language insights into daily workflows — to help AI initiatives shift from pilot to production. Artha's data foundation services encompass data intelligence functions that include data cataloging, lineage, quality, and observability. These capabilities enable organizations to achieve centralized governance while maintaining decentralized data access, a critical requirement for supporting federated data models and AI use cases. By implementing robust data intelligence practices, Artha helps organizations gain visibility into their data assets, improve data quality, and ensure compliance with regulatory requirements.

A key differentiator of Artha's offering is the integration of Qlik Talend's certified data integration engine. This platform supports a wide range of data integration functions, including ETL/ELT, data replication, federation, and mastering. The solution aims to facilitate seamless migration from legacy ETL tools through a fast convert-to-Qlik utility, so organizations can modernize their data infrastructure with minimal disruption. This one-click conversion capability is useful for organizations seeking to consolidate technical debt and accelerate their journey toward modern, AI-ready data architectures.

Artha's managed services extend beyond data integration to provide end-to-end support for business applications and data pipelines. This includes Level 2 and Level 3 support, infrastructure maintenance, and the ongoing management of data environments. The company has strengths in healthcare, banking, financial services, and telecom verticals, leveraging its experience with major clients in these sectors to provide tailored solutions that address industry-specific regulatory and operational requirements.

Data readiness for AI is a core focus of Artha's services. The company designs its offerings to prepare data for predictive, generative, and agentic AI initiatives by enabling governance, quality, cataloging, and master data management. This comprehensive approach means that organizations have access to high-quality, timely, and relevant data, which is essential for training and deploying effective AI models.

Artha's global presence allows the company to support clients in diverse geographies. With headquarters and offices in key regions, the company leverages its experience with major healthcare, banking, manufacturing, and retail enterprises to deliver solutions that are both globally informed and locally relevant.

Artha adopts an advisory and consultative engagement model, emphasizing actionable recommendations and non-promotional guidance. Its approach involves advising organizations on solutions that best meet their needs, rather than pushing specific products or services, fostering long-term partnerships based on trust and measurable outcomes.

Challenges

The journey toward AI-ready data architecture is complex, requiring both technical modernization and organizational transformation. Organizations must navigate technical challenges such as ensuring data security, privacy, and governance; managing the accuracy and relevance of AI outcomes; maintaining data quality; and handling the intricacies of AI model training and tuning. They must also manage expectations around AI capabilities, address skills and resource constraints, deal with changing business priorities, and overcome collaboration barriers between business and IT. To meet these challenges, companies must implement a combination of technical solutions and organizational strategies. Service providers and technology partners can play a pivotal role in guiding companies through this transformation by offering expertise and support in navigating complexity, implementing best practices, and accelerating the adoption of AI-ready data architecture.

Coordinating SLAs, support responsibilities, and upgrade cycles across the joint Artha and Qlik solution may be difficult, especially as customer needs evolve and new features are introduced. Lines of accountability can blur — who owns an incident, who maintains what, and who signs off for audits — as scope grows. Timelines can drift if the enterprise road map and the platform road map move at different speeds. CIOs should expect these tensions and judge the partnership on how clearly roles, timelines, and dependencies are defined from the start.

Conclusion

The evolution of enterprise intelligence hinges on the ability to establish a unified, AI-ready data foundation that integrates governance, quality, and real-time access across distributed environments. As organizations confront increasing complexity, regulatory demands, and the imperative to scale AI, expert data foundation services offer a pathway to measurable improvements in agility, efficiency, and innovation. The strategic relevance of robust data foundation services is clear: They are the catalyst for trusted, scalable, and transformative business outcomes in a rapidly changing digital landscape. If Artha and Qlik can address these challenges, they and their partnership have significant opportunities for success.

Expert data foundation services offer a pathway to measurable improvements in agility, efficiency, and innovation.

About the Analysts

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Stewart Bond is research vice president of IDC's Data Intelligence and Integration Software service. Mr. Bond's core research coverage includes watching emerging trends that are shaping and changing data movement, ingestion, transformation, mastering, cleansing, and consumption in the era of digital business. Having worked in the IT industry for over 30 years, from early experience in database and application development through solution design and deployment to strategic architectural consulting, Stewart has worked through some significant changes in the IT industry.

***Reid Sherard,** Research Manager, Enterprise Intelligence Services*

Reid Sherard is a research manager for IDC's Worldwide Services team, working on Enterprise Intelligence Services research covering the life cycle of project-oriented, managed, and support services related to the deployment of data management, analytics, artificial intelligence (AI), and automation. His research focuses on how service providers work with organizations to ensure investments in enterprise intelligence achieve their objectives and result in positive return on investment.

MESSAGE FROM THE SPONSOR

Data is growing fast and spreading across apps, clouds, and teams. Without clear control, it turns into silos, extra cost, and AI that never leaves pilot.

Artha Solutions Data Foundation Services make data ready for AI. Artha sets the operating model—catalog, lineage, quality, privacy, and always-on monitoring — while Qlik provides the integration backbone for CDC/replication, ELT, and federation. Together, they connect the systems that create and use data so people get trusted, governed access to both structured and unstructured information.

With Artha, customers can:

- Ship AI faster – Clean, connected data and reusable building blocks turn pilots into live products.
- Trust every decision – See where data came from, keep it fresh, and catch drift or bias before it reaches downstream.
- Scale without surprises – Use open standards and move compute to the data to cut hidden costs and avoid lock-in.

Learn more about Artha Solutions AI offering at https://www.thinkartha.com/artificial-intelligence/.

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